Source: Photo by Jackie McCabe



Subsequent reforms opened Cuba to foreign investment and joint ventures, allowed Cubans to work for foreign entities, promoted tourism, and legalized certain forms of self-employment. Foreign and joint ventures were especially sought in the mining (nickel), energy (oil and gas) and tourism sectors, while free trade zones were established to attract foreign manufacturers. Artisans markets where producers could sell directly to the public were opened. The "dash of capitalism" that Benjamin *et al.* had identified in the early 1980s was becoming a torrent. In 2000, 22 percent of Cuba's workers were employed in the non-state sector – either through self-employment, or working for foreign enterprises.[5] Self-employment reached a high of 156,600 workers in 1999, until new policies started to rein in some of these opportunities.[6]

As part of the campaign for foreign exchange, the Cuban government started to encourage emigrants to visit. It relaxed visa restrictions for Cuban Americans, and allowed them, for the first time, to stay with relatives rather than in hotels. The number of return visits skyrocketed, from only 7000 in 1990 to over 80,000 a year between 1994 and 2001.[7]

The government offered a basic rationale for all of the rapid-fire economic changes between 1993 and 1995 and the apparent contradictions they brought with them. Faced with the loss of its Soviet-bloc trade and aid, the Cuban economy had gone into a tailspin after